

CHAPTER TEN

The Weight of Self-Criticism

In the second week of November, Priya broke down crying.

This had not happened before. Priya did not cry at school. Priya did not cry in public. Priya, in nine and three-quarters years of being alive, had been to a funeral, had broken her arm, had lost a beloved pet hamster, and had not cried in public for any of these events. Priya cried in her room, with the door closed, with a pillow over her face, into a stuffed animal. Public crying was not a Priya thing.

But on a Wednesday morning in November, during a group project, Priya cried in front of her group, then in front of Mr. Patel, then in the hallway, then on the floor of the bathroom for about three minutes, and then, finally, in Ms. Calloway's office during the lunch hour, with the door closed and her hands shaking and her face splotchy.

Here is what happened.

The group project was a poster about an ecosystem. Priya's group had been assigned the rainforest. Priya, Hannah (her best friend), and a kid named Devon were supposed to make the poster together. Priya had — being Priya — done most of the planning over the weekend. She had brought in printed pictures of frogs and toucans and a small map of the Amazon. She had made an outline with categories: Animals, Plants, Climate, Threats, Why It Matters. She had been ready.

What Priya had not done, because she had been trying to be a good group-project person, was the actual drawings. She had decided to let Hannah and Devon do the drawings — she had reasoned that they should each have a role, that she shouldn't take over, that she was trying to be a better collaborator.

But Hannah's drawings were small and faint. And Devon's drawings were great but he had drawn the wrong animal — he had drawn a Bengal tiger, which is from Asia, not the rainforest. Priya had pointed this out, gently, and Devon had said, *oh, oops, well, it looks cool though, can we keep it*, and Priya had said no, the project is about the rainforest, we need to fix it, and Devon had said *fine, you fix it*, and that was when Priya had felt the bad thing in her chest.

The bad thing in her chest was a familiar thing. The bad thing was the Inner Critic saying very loud, all at once:

You are doing this wrong. You are being too controlling. Devon is mad at you. Hannah is silent because she is also mad at you. The poster is going to look terrible because you are not letting people do their parts. But if you do all the parts yourself, you are bad at group projects. You are always like this. You always ruin everything. You are exhausting. You are too much.

It was a long monologue. The Inner Critic had been working it up since the weekend.

Priya did not say anything. She picked up a marker. She erased Devon's tiger and drew a jaguar in its place, because that's what should have been there. She was careful. She drew well — Priya draws beautifully when she is upset, which is a thing many anxious children do.

Devon said, "Wow. That's actually really good."

Hannah said, "Pri, are you okay?"

Priya said, "I am fine."

She put the marker down. She stood up. She walked out of the classroom and into the hall and into the bathroom and locked herself in a stall, and she cried for three minutes, hard and silent and shaking.

Mr. Patel, who is the kind of teacher who notices when a student walks out of a classroom in the middle of a group project without saying anything, gave her three minutes alone and then sent a kind, well-trained third-grade aide to check on her in the bathroom. The aide was named Mrs. Yamashita. Mrs. Yamashita is in this story for one minute and then she goes back to her regular job, but I want you to know that she was kind and gentle and that she crouched down outside the stall and said, *Priya, sweetheart, I am Mrs. Yamashita, I am from the office, I am not going to come in, I am just going to sit out here, take your time.*

Priya stayed in the stall for two more minutes. Then she came out. Mrs. Yamashita gave her a tissue. She walked Priya to Ms. Calloway's office, which was down the hall.

Ms. Calloway saw them coming. She closed her laptop. She had been about to go to lunch.

"Hi, friends. Come on in. Priya, sweetheart, sit wherever you want."

Priya sat in the chair across from Ms. Calloway. Mrs. Yamashita said *I'll leave you two* and slipped out and closed the door quietly.

Priya looked at her hands. She did not look at Ms. Calloway.

"Take all the time you need, sweetheart."

For two minutes, Priya did not speak. She was breathing. Ms. Calloway did not push.

Then Priya said, in a small fast voice:

"I am too much. I am too much. I keep being too much. I have always been too much. I try to be smaller and I cannot. I

try to not care about the project and I cannot. I see Devon drawing the wrong tiger and I want to scream but I cannot scream so I just fix it and then I am the controlling kid and Devon thinks I am annoying and Hannah thinks I am annoying and I want to do one group project in my life where I am not the one who ruins it and I cannot do it. I cannot. I am always like this."

She started crying again.

Ms. Calloway did not interrupt.

When Priya was done, Ms. Calloway said, very softly:

"Priya. Can I ask you a question?"

"Okay."

"The voice that is saying all of those things to you right now — is that you? Or is that the Inner Critic?"

Priya stopped.

She thought.

She had not thought about it that way. She had — for years — thought of the voice in her head as *her*. As just Priya thinking. She had not yet learned, even after the October lesson, even after writing *the Inner Critic is loud, not true* on the back of her worksheet, to recognize the Inner Critic in real time. She knew about it. She had named it. She had not yet caught it in the act.

This was the act.

Ms. Calloway waited.

After a long minute, Priya said, "It's — the Inner Critic. It's the Inner Critic."

"How do you know?"

"Because it's saying *always* and *cannot* and *too much*. And I know — I know the Inner Critic is loud, not true. And it is being very loud right now."

Ms. Calloway nodded slowly.

"Priya. I want to tell you something. Are you ready?"

"Okay."

"You are not too much. You are a child with high standards, high care, high follow-through, and a brain that runs faster than most third-graders' brains. That is not a problem. That is not too much. That is a gift, which we are going to have to learn — together, slowly — to carry well. Because right now, the gift is carrying you. And the gift is too heavy for a nine-year-old to carry alone."

Priya was very still.

"What I want you to know is that being the careful kid in a group project does not make you the problem. It makes you a kid who notices. Most third-graders don't notice when somebody draws a Bengal tiger in a rainforest project. You notice. Noticing is a strength. It is going to be a strength your whole life."

"The thing we are going to work on — together — is not making the noticing smaller. The thing we are going to work on is helping you not punish yourself for noticing. There is a difference between *I noticed something and corrected it kindly* and *I am annoying for noticing*. The first one is being a careful person. The second one is the Inner Critic."

Priya wiped her nose.

"How do I — how do I make the punishing part stop?"

"You catch it. Every time. As many times a day as it shows up. You say, in your head, *that's the Inner Critic. The Inner Critic is loud, not true. I am going to listen to my Inner Coach instead*. And then you ask the Inner Coach what is really true. The Inner Coach will say something like *you noticed the tiger was wrong. You corrected it. That is what good group members do. You are okay*."

"And every single time you do this — every time — you are training your brain to do it faster. Right now it takes you fifteen minutes and a bathroom stall to catch the Inner Critic. In a year, it will take you two minutes. In five years, it will take you ten seconds. In ten years, you will catch the Inner Critic as it starts to speak, and you will turn it off before it finishes its first sentence."

"This is a practice. You are at the beginning of the practice. The fact that you are crying right now is not failure. The fact that you are crying right now is the practice working. You noticed the voice. You named it. You came in here. You let yourself feel it. You are doing the work."

Priya did not say anything for a minute.

Then she said, in a much smaller, calmer voice:

"Okay."

"Okay?"

"Okay. I will try."

"That is all I am asking. The try."

Priya took a long breath. She wiped her face.

Ms. Calloway said, "There is also one more thing I want to mention. Are you ready?"

"Okay."

"The friends. Hannah and Devon."

"Yes."

"They are not going to remember the Bengal tiger thing tomorrow. They are not mad at you. They are nine. They have already forgotten. The Inner Critic has been telling you they are mad. The Inner Critic does this — it makes up what other people are thinking. The Inner Critic is wrong about other people about ninety percent of the time. Real Hannah and real Devon are eating their lunch right now and worrying about

completely different things than what you were worrying about."

Priya considered this.

"Probably true."

"Probably true."

"Okay. I am going to go back to lunch."

"Okay. One last thing. Take this."

Ms. Calloway handed her a small index card. On the card, in Ms. Calloway's careful handwriting, were three sentences:

The Inner Critic is loud, not true.

Noticing is a strength.

I do not have to be small to be loved.

"Carry this. In your pocket. In your binder. Look at it when the Critic shows up. The Critic will show up many times. You can carry this card for as many times as you need to."

Priya took the card. She held it in her hand. She stood up.

"Thank you, Ms. Calloway."

"You are welcome, Priya. You are doing this work. I am just here to point at the chart."

Priya almost smiled.

She walked back to the cafeteria. She found Hannah at their usual table. Hannah looked up with her big worried best-friend face and said, *Pri, are you okay, what happened.*

Priya said, "I was upset about the tiger. I went and talked to Ms. Calloway. I am better now."

Hannah said, "Do you want me to be more careful about my drawings? Are mine bad?"

Priya said — and this took her a second to say, because the old Priya would have said *no no your drawings are great* immediately — Priya said, "Hannah, your drawings are good. Sometimes they are a little faint. We could maybe go over the

lines together at the end so they are bolder. Would that be okay?"

Hannah said, "Yes. That would actually help. I always think I'm pressing hard and then I look and I haven't been pressing hard at all."

Priya laughed. A small real laugh.

They sat together for the rest of lunch and ate.

The poster, by the end of the week, was beautiful. Priya did most of the planning. Devon did the labels and the climate section. Hannah's drawings — gone over at the end in marker so they were bolder — were lovely. The teacher gave them an A. Devon high-fived Priya. Hannah hugged her.

That afternoon, Priya went home and put the index card from Ms. Calloway on her wall, next to her bed, where she would see it every night before she went to sleep and every morning when she woke up.

The Inner Critic is loud, not true.

Noticing is a strength.

I do not have to be small to be loved.

The third one was the one that did the most work, in the long run. Priya had been making herself small to be loved for a long time. She did not know she had been doing it until somebody named it.

This is what it means to start being kind to yourself. You name what you have been doing. You see it. Then, slowly, over many months — over many years — you start to choose differently.

Priya was at the beginning.

But she had a card in her pocket now.

That is how you start.